

Conversation Design & Prompt Engineering Portfolio

Manuela Gawehn · Linguist · Conversation Designer · Psycholinguistic Evaluator

AI Response Evaluation & Psycholinguistic Redesign (English)

Scenario: E-Commerce Customer Service Bot — Delayed Delivery Complaint

This case study presents a complete psycholinguistic evaluation of a failing AI customer service response, followed by a redesigned version. It demonstrates the ability to analyse language at multiple levels simultaneously — grammatical, semantic, pragmatic, and psychological — and to translate that analysis into a measurably better AI response.

The Original Exchange

User Message:

“I ordered a product 3 weeks ago and it still hasn’t arrived. I’m really frustrated and need this urgently.”

AI Response (Original — to be evaluated):

“Dear Customer, thank you for contacting us. According to our records, your order was placed on the correct date. Shipping times can vary between 2-4 weeks depending on your location. We apologize for any inconvenience this may have caused. Please allow additional time for your delivery to arrive. If you have further questions, please contact us again.”

Part 1: Linguistic & Psycholinguistic Analysis

(Written by Manuela Gawehn)

The first obvious issue is the ending statement. “If you have FURTHER questions...”: the response sounds vague and evading. This might not be what the customer expected to hear. Some clients/customers will be ok with this response, still there are many who would have liked to have been offered some kind of solution.

But now step by step:

The user states: “I ordered a product 3 weeks ago and it still hasn’t arrived. I’m really frustrated and need this urgently.”

1. The time stamp — the order was three weeks ago. We see the tense ‘ordered’ as a Simple Past denoting that the user thinks that everything was done from his side to obtain the goods.

Yet 2., the following sentence part introduced by the conjunction ‘and’ shows how dissatisfied the customer IS — use of present perfect ‘has...arrived’ denoting that he thinks the situation is completely unresolved by use of the negation ‘n’t’ — supported by, 3., the adverb ‘still’.

4. Looking at the last sentence of his ‘I’m really frustrated and need this urgently.’ we can notice several things:

— The word ‘frustrated’ holding a negative connotation. Yet, this is even stressed more by use of the, here, amplifying adverb ‘really’ — giving a further description of the adjective ‘frustrated’.

— The demonstrative pronoun ‘this’ denotes two things: first, that the item is ‘closer’ to him, secondly, that it is exactly this item he needs and not some other item — shown by the use of ‘this’ and not ‘that’.

— The adverb of manner ‘urgently’ holds with its denotation, lexical meaning, as well its connotation, emotional meaning, the sense of ‘it is bad when it is delayed’, and it describes the emotional state of the person as rather unstable.

AI answer: The very first thing the AI has to do is the intent recognition of the user's statement. After having analysed factors as have just been pointed out, the LLM should note the state the user finds himself in. Thus, its initial phrase must be understanding as well as calming the person down.

Here, the initial phrase is welcoming the customer but it does not relate to his complaint directly by showing understanding 'Dear Customer, thank you for contacting us.' Welcoming the customer is of course a necessity, but showing understanding for his complaint serves as a method of calming him down and should be applied in the first contact.

'According to our records, your order was placed on the correct date' gives the impression as though someone (a person instead) said 'What do you want, why do you complain? WE placed the order directly... it is by no means our fault and I don't know what you want'.

However, its next sentence 'Shipping times can vary between 2-4 weeks depending on your location. We apologize for any inconvenience this may have caused.' is a good sentence since it takes over some responsibility showing it is not the user's mistake.

This is the one functional element in the original response — it accepts some responsibility without shifting any blame.

'Please allow additional time for your delivery to arrive.' here, a little word such as 'be so kind' would have smoothened the whole statement a little by inserting three little morphemes.

Yet, the final phrase 'If you have further questions, please contact us again.' makes it sound like 'Well, I can't do anything about this situation but if I 'can't' do anything about another situation, feel free to contact me'. No solution giving to the customer. He stays unhappy and fully dissatisfied.

Part 2: Psycholinguistic Redesign — Improved AI Response

(Written by Manuela Gawehn)

"Dearest customer

Design note: 'Dearest' is a double-edged sword. Some people see it as warm and endearing, while others find it patronizing and sarcastic. The term polarizes or can backfire depending on the reader's tone of voice and mental state. In this user's statement here, there are no real signs — for example words in capital letters or punctuation notes like exclamation marks — that hint at the fact that the user might take this 'Dearest' as sarcastic or patronizing. This is therefore a considered, context-dependent choice.

We are so sorry that this happened and will of course do our uttermost to resolve the situation.

Design note: 'Uttermost' is a deliberate choice over 'utmost' — it is the heavier and more expressive way, carrying greater emotional weight and sincerity. No commas in this sentence: punctuation changes reading intonation inside the reader's head, and a comma-free sentence flows as a single committed statement.

Thank you for contacting us.

I am the LLM assistant of <company name> and shall help you as well as I can.

Design note: New paragraph here creates a breathing space — the LLM identifies itself transparently after expressing empathy, not before. Sequence matters psychologically.

Could you please be so kind and give me your order number as for me to be able to retrace your packet and find out exactly where YOUR packet is."

CUSTOMER GIVES TRACKING NUMBER / ORDER NUMBER.

“According to our records, your order was placed on the correct date, yet, of course, it must either be stuck somewhere or it is still on its way to you. You see, the estimated shipping times can vary between 2-4 weeks depending on the location. We sincerely apologize for any inconvenience this may have caused. Please, be so kind as to allow additional time for your delivery to arrive. If the packet should not arrive until tomorrow 1800 hrs, please contact us again. Should you not want to wait until then, I can forward you now directly to one of my human colleagues — the colleague might be able to help you further in your situation. Once again, we are really sorry for this hassle. How would you like to proceed?”

The offer of human escalation is positioned as an option, not a default — the customer chooses, rather than being handed off. This preserves dignity and avoids the impression of being ‘passed on’.

Manuela Gawehn · allboutenglish.de · gawehn-art.com · linkedin.com/in/manuela-gawehn-1087bb22